Joe Lollo
BIS 488 A
Alice Pedersen
12 March 2021

Queerness in Gothic Literature

A decidedly "British" literary culture was established around the time the Gothic genre came around, which concurrently acted as criticism of nearly every aspect of British culture. Despite this, there are still lingering queries and whispers of the nature of sexuality throughout this genre, which has never been given a standard. Strong representations of the struggle with sexuality during the "classic" Gothic movement are presented in *The Monk* by Matthew Lewis. While Matilda is a clear antagonist, representing several Gothic terrors, her sexuality liberates her from the ideologies most women at the time were constrained to, despite subverting this by not being a woman after all. The portrayal of Matilda's merely performative femininity against Ambrosio's weakened masculinity from his Catholic upbringing, however, paved the way for the exploration of queer sexuality in the Gothic. Sheridan Le Fanu's novella *Carmilla* marked a continued exploration of sexuality after Lewis's novel, presenting new expressions of sexuality. Le Fanu paved the way for the subgenre of "vampire fiction," where the character of the vampire represents a younger, changing generation resistant to the dominant culture's traditional standards by being open towards sexuality. The figure of the vampire in *Carmilla* is a heavily coded way to explore social anxieties related to queerness in a safe fashion. In a similar vein to these novels, Helen Oyeyemi's contemporary novel *White is For Witching* features a new take on the classic Gothic horror and vampire story, featuring new takes on the same traditions using the discourse and terror affiliated with consumption. While there are clear expressions of queer sexuality and uncanny terrors, the novel represents several new fears in contemporary British culture, with sexuality sidelined or even eliminated at some points to tell more impactful female stories. Exploring the intersectionality between sexuality and literature, and how it evolved throughout the history of the Gothic genre and influenced modern forms of literature, this essay assesses concurs that the images of sexuality and gender norms in the Gothic genre were not only highly influential towards modern literature, but also important representations of openness with identities that were concealed in earlier literary movements.

The Monk deeply intertwines sexuality and morality, with "moral" women being chaste while "immoral" women are sexually predatory. Much of the novel revolves around the dynamics of sexual control and morality, with the impure sexual relationship between Ambrosio, the titular monk, and his temptress Matilda being a focal point. The role of women in the novel provides readers with good insight into the gender ideologies at the time of its publication, as Matilda's transgression of the cultural standard of virtue is what leads to her demise. Matilda tempts Ambrosio into embracing worldly desires, recklessly embracing her sexuality in the process. She spends several days seducing Ambrosio with the intent of leading him down a dark path, reprimanding his values of chastity as "unnatural" due to "man [not being] created in such a state" (Lewis, 156). Matilda's assertiveness and awareness of her sexuality directly belittle values central to Catholicism, deviating from the expectations of "womanlike" conduct in the eighteenth century. She quickly becomes an object of Ambrosio's desire, which develops into a relationship characterized by manipulation and a "primitive" sexual nature.

Matilda is a polarizing female figure in the novel as she knows what she wants and employs any means necessary to achieve it, including aiding Ambrosio in his sexual pursuit of Antonia. Once Ambrosio breaks his vows and confesses his desire for Antonia, he chastises Matilda saying she "corrupted" him, and "spent his passion" (Lewis, 159). Their relationship starts to wane because of this, with him only staying with Matilda for the sexual pleasure she provides him with, and becomes the embodiment of ant-Catholic values. This is made apparent in Lewis's description of Matilda's sexual advances, as their relationship is described in gendered terms of the opposite gender. Matilda takes the lead, "[penetrating] into his very soul," and she is masculinized when demonized, a contrast to the "weak" and feminine creature that Ambrosio has become under the church walls (Lewis, 83). This gendered relationship becomes increasingly overt as the novel progresses, as there are explicit hints that Ambrosio has been emasculated by his tenure as a Catholic priest. He was unprepared to face the temptations of a worldly woman, and his naïvety towards sexuality created a propensity for perversion in his adult life thanks to a woman's "gift." Matilda is aware that she is corrupting the chastity central to Catholicism by corrupting a religious figure and uses her looks and beauty to achieve her end goal of having Ambrosio stay with her forever and do everything she asks, considered an ultimate form of manipulation.

Once Matilda successfully gains control of Ambrosio, their unnatural gender relations are solidified when he makes a pact with the Devil[1], and the novel reveals that Matilda was his disguise this entire time. In *The Monk*'s denouement, Satan reemphasizes the link between demonic possession and sexual corruption by telling Ambrosio that he must have his soul forever, stating "mine you must and shall be" (Lewis, 297). This same phrase was said by Matilda, Satan's disguise, when she revealed her false lust for him, and by Ambrosio when he rapes Antonia. While Ambrosio reclaims his male identity in his rape of Antonia, he is ultimately re-feminized by Satan, with the final nail in the coffin coming from his death. Satan, in the form of a giant bird, drops him from a great height after promising to let him escape, leading him to be penetrated by the "sharp point of a rock," which "tore his flesh piecemeal" (Lewis, 301-302). There is an unmistakable phallic allusion among the final phrases, which is an echo of Ambrosio's initial emasculation under Matilda's vices. By reading this "truth" of Matilda's gender, Lewis might be critiquing the ideology that men must always occupy a dominant position over women in relation to desire and lust, thus "queering" the nature of Catholicism's traditions. Ambrosio's temptation, and its juxtaposition with the supernatural horrors he faces towards the end of the novel, expose the construction of gender and performative identities – Satan, a Biblical villain historically interpreted as male, manipulates the gendered expectations of women through his ambiguous intentions. Satan's disguise as Matilda disturbs a binary that British culture upheld, and reading it provokes a queer take on the Gothic terrors that arises from the anxiety of seeing and understanding the ways people can disturb sex-gender binaries with their ambiguous gender performance.

Roughly a century later, Sheridan Le Fanu's 1872 novella *Carmilla* brought this burgeoning perspective to the surface in a more obvious way than *The Monk* did – while the supernatural queerness in *The Monk* is only an interpretation, the "dangerous" queer desires in Le Fanu's tale lie at the center of its narrative. Carmilla, among the other vampires talked about in the novel, represented a foreign Other feared by many, which alongside her queer sexual desires classify her as an "abhorrent yet exciting" figure to Laura (Le Fanu, 29). "Curiosity is a restless passion that no one can endure," Laura laments at one point, and this restless passion

[1] While modern publications of *The Monk* often omit the reference to Satan and call Matilda's transformation a "Dæmon" or demon, the Oxford World Classics version, based on Lewis's own text, explicitly mentions Satan by name. Regardless, he is always classified as male and given male pronouns.

manifests in her anxiety towards reconciling the jumbled attraction and repulsion that Carmilla makes her feel, an ambiguous feeling whose origins readers are traditionally unsure about (Le Fanu, 27). Carmilla occupies two unique identities that contribute to the novella's overt theme of invasion, another, greater, purpose is that vampires are representative of a growing society of foreign people, Others, if you will, who worked opposite the Victorian man or woman due to their free sexual expression. While vampires in *Carmilla* are representative of a more open regard to sexuality in British culture, they are still considered immoral and inherently "evil."

According to the newer but still "standard" social conventions brought to England by the Victorian era, Laura should ultimately resist a temptress like Matilda, yet she does the opposite and actively engages her. The novella ends with Laura "fancying" hearing Carmilla at her door despite having seen her death (Le Fanu, 90). Laura retains her sexual and social agency despite the patriarchal aversion to Carmilla's existence expressed through male authority figures, as her "love" defies the heteronormative "relationship," promoted by Victorian society and characterized by the bond between a man and woman. Carmilla uses her mystical powers to usurp Victorian male authority, bestowing herself upon the girl she loves and excluding any male participation. Male authority figures throughout the book try to prevent them from being with each other, such as General Spielsdorf, a prototypical Victorian male who attempts to convince Laura's father that Carmilla is "dangerous and improper" in her conduct (Le Fanu, 32). But as men like the General are powerless around Carmilla, the story could be read as a tale of queer resistance against the Victorian patriarchy. Le Fanu not only acknowledges the existence of female queerness and sexual agency by centering it as a divergence from heteronormative standards, but gives these young women a form of sexual comfort in a time when they were prohibited from exhibiting any form of sexual desire (Costello-Sullivan, iii).[2]

Laura's fancy is a simultaneous attraction and fear, which relates to the fact that Carmilla is free from the control of men. When she is with Carmilla, Laura exists within a world where male authority does not exist, causing her to be physically and emotionally available to her queer temptations. When Carmilla first arrives at Laura's house, Laura is confused by her affection, and wonders if she is a "boyish lover in a masquerade," as the only way she could understand this attraction was imagining her as a boy in disguise (Le Fanu, 18). This shows the extent to

[2] This reading was assisted by the introductory essay by Kate Costello-Sullivan at the beginning of the 2019 Syracuse University Press edition of *Carmilla*. Other editions of the novella do not feature this essay.

which female sexuality was repressed to make a "proper" lady, ultimately restoring Victorian values upon Carmilla's demise. As a queer, female-passing "creature" from a place not under British rule, Carmilla is the Other, and the Gothic terror that comes with reading her actions may be a cautionary one, warning readers that an acceptance of open, queer sexuality could threaten heteronormative culture in the long run. This harkens back to Ambrosio's initial demise in *The Monk*, as he is corrupted by a person he initially believes to be a young male monk who is later revealed to be a woman (and then a male-passing demon) in disguise, much like Laura's imagining of Carmilla as a boy in disguise, as both believe the cultural norms they were taught in the places they were raised in. Yet despite the freedom from corruption and restoration of traditional values at the end of each narrative, *Carmilla* represents some progression in the acceptance of queer identities in literary and public spheres, as there is a much more open display of a queer relationship compared to the ambiguous gender performance of Matilda.

Two centuries later, vampires have a hold over many sorts of fans, as the popularity of Le Fanu's work, alongside others, inadvertently created a horde of Gothic stories dedicated purely to vampires. These creatures of the night have changed over the years, with some vampiric figures being less apparent in later literary works, such as Miranda in Helen Oyeyemi's 2009 novel *White is For Witching*. While not openly a vampire, her eating disorder makes her very similar to one, and her relationship with Ore displays a much more open view on queer sexuality synonymous with its acceptance in contemporary British culture in the twenty-first century.

White is For Witching represents the same fear of the outsider, openness with sexuality, and unnatural appetites that the traditional vampire story tells, only using the Caribbean folk tale of the Soucoyant[3] as a narrative device. While both are creatures that suck on blood, the Soucoyant is "a double danger discontent with herself," through both "meeting her and being her," which happens to Miranda as she becomes discontent with herself over time (Oyeyemi, 112). While Miranda tells her lover Ore that she is a danger to her while they become romantically attached, the only apparent signs of this "danger," however, are from Miranda's pica, her eating disorder where she eats things that aren't food (chalk in her case). Consumption, both sexually and through literal eating, becomes the major preoccupation of the second half. As a queer woman with the desire to consume, much like Matilda and Carmilla, Miranda is a

[3] There is much debate as to whether the Soucoyant is a "real" vampire or not – the only difference seems to be country/culture of origin.

modern version of the Gothic temptress, and Oyeyemi interrogates the nature of sexuality through the concept of consumption.

The focus on consumption as a trope in the novel encompasses many consumptive activities that take place within or inside the haunted house. The house desires to consume Miranda, associated with her consuming body and disease by strengthening her desire for non-food, which leads to her becoming the vampire. Miranda becomes pale, "her form emaciated," and her body a signifier of her fractured identity" (Oyeyemi, 21). Her identity is understood by her lover as being bound to her consumption and illness, and thus imprisoned by it. Ore thought of Miranda as a "Gothic victim," a "child-woman too pretty and good for this world who ends up dying of tuberculosis or grief" once she learns of Miranda's condition (Oyeyemi, 1117). The consumption of the body is associated here with Victorian obsessions with bodily boundaries, and Miranda's appetite condemns her body, defied rather than demonized. Miranda is "pure" and described as "thin as an ivory wand" due to her whiteness, and her wasting and weak body becomes "good" for the Soucoyant to control, rendering her the vampire (Oyeyemi, 138). The ties between illness and vampirism are explored deeper in Oyeyemi's novel than *Carmilla*, which is significant as these figures and practices are additionally gendered. As it was in the Victorian era and portrayed in *Carmilla*, the connections of disease and "monstrosity" draw attention to the "inferior" status of a woman in a patriarchal culture – like Miranda, whose body and identity are controlled through the trope of consumption. Just like Carmilla's vampirism passed down along the female line of her family, the unnatural consumption from pica that Miranda has was also passed down from her maternal lineage. While her great-grandmother Anna once "consumed herself" and drank her own blood, the rest of her family developed pica. Anna's auto-vampirism serves as the origin of the history of consumption in the family, yet the gradual movement away from the consumption of blood suggests a break away from the past and into a new era of vampirism (Oyeyemi, 23-24).

Miranda's dangerous appetite is juxtaposed with Ore, whose appetite for British food becomes associated with her status as a queer African woman. Ore's consumption of British food and symbols through her relationship and learning from Miranda is linked to mobility without assimilation in the dominant behaviors. Being the child of a Nigerian immigrant, she consumes British culture by being around others, and her identity transgresses boundaries without taking on fully the limitations of a single nationality. She refuses her categorization as an "Other"

according to her sexuality, race, and color which should marginalize her in British society, and fluidly navigates through her complex identity and reality. The vampire is no longer purely associated with the fear of the Other in this modern vampire story, as it is now displayed in the victim. Ore's fluid identity is a form of resistance against fixed classifications, offering a diverse identity not confined to a specific origin. The Soucoyant, taking the form of other ghostly women in Miranda's house, immediately threatens Ore due to her presence rivaling "traditional" forms of autonomy and hegemony – histories of immigration repeatedly "invade" the domestic sphere of this house, which insists on keeping the outside separate from its private and secure inside. This house also consumes and controls women in it – in a flashback when Miranda's great-grandfather Andrew was killed in World War II, her great-grandmother Anna asks it to bring him back, saying "I hate them. Blackies, Germans, killers – dirty killers. He should have stayed with me" (Oyeyemi, 118). Anna's hatred is rooted in – and brought to life by – a historical moment associated with racism, and her own fear of the Other animates the house and gives it the task to repel the Other. The house's consciousness, connected to xenophobia and imperial nostalgia, is an additional manifestation of the uncanny – it is aware of what it is doing, and believes it is fine to do. Oyeyemi's novel manipulates the house's beliefs by bringing the concept of racism, previously not discretely talked about in the Gothic tradition, to the surface, and reclaiming the colonial past. The sexuality often synonymous with Gothic terrors is not made an apparent threat in *White is For Witching*, it is sidelined in favor of more pertinent threats to contemporary society, evident of the modern cultural changes surrounding the text.

While the Soucoyant's racism attacks the Other and attempts to initiate Miranda into erasing difference, Miranda desires to find completion through consuming Ore. Miranda "needed Ore open. Her head spun with the desire to taste…she lay her head on Ore's chest and heard her heart…this heart barely moved. Miranda could have taken it," yet instead consumes her own blood to protect Ore, because she knows that "Ore is not food, and [she thinks she is] a monster" (Oyeyemi, 138). The white subject is presented as the Other during their sexual interaction, as she is a blood-drinker, which ironically reverses the discourse of the Other as a cannibal which novels like *Carmilla* were rampant with. Miranda's consumption of Ore is also within the boundaries of what is "civilized" – Ore starts to get thinner and thinner, and begins to realize the dangerous effects of Miranda's vampirism, while being with Ore leads to Miranda's life being taken slowly. When Ore kisses Miranda, she becomes aware of "something leaving [her]," yet

the consumption is purely queer and out of love, not controlled by the Soucoyant or associated with the domination and consumption of the Other that it would desire. Miranda's mind and body are inhabited by the Soucoyant, and her "dangerous" sexual desires are bound by the Soucoyant and its evil powers. While there are many ways this story lacks the traditional Gothic sexuality, the Soucoyant is a prominent sexual threat. Like Carmilla to Laura, the Soucoyant renders Miranda as a queer and very feminized figure. But while her sexuality is liberated, her femininity binds her to vampirism and monstrosity, representing a similar threat of the Other. And much like Matilda/Satan in *The Monk* and her temptation of Ambrosio, this vampiric figure's possession of Miranda is a true danger – the romantic fantasies of pleasure and danger are commonly associated with sexuality, yet unlike Matilda's corruption of Ambrosio, it is the corrupter who is made weaker while devouring its victims and leaving them emptier. *White is For Witching* subverts the traditional threat of the Other by exposing new Gothic terrors related to contemporary British culture, making the line between "victim" and "vampire" standard to the genre a much blurrier one. The white subject, who would be purely a victim in any other Gothic novel, is the bloodsucker and consumer, yet she can experience other pleasures besides the bloodsucking, representing a departure from the traditional standards of the Gothic genre.

The marked changes in expressions of queer sexuality from early Gothic novels like *The Monk* to twenty-first century works such as *White is For Witching* show a great change in how sexuality, and openness with it, has evolved over three centuries. While patriarchy and religion influence every aspect of morality and condemn sexuality in *The Monk*, these themes weakened in *Carmilla*, to the point where they are only used to destroy the sexual being in the end while letting the queer figures roam free in the beginning. The exploration of queer sexuality in the Gothic is fully liberated in *White is For Witching*, which puts sexuality in a vampire story but does not make it a central point of conflict. While early works of vampire fiction like *Carmilla* marked a staunch resistance to the vampires due to their sexuality, *White is For Witching* was aware that there were bigger threats to address in contemporary culture, and the romance with a vampire is protected and fostered. Culture changes constantly, and the Gothic is consistently synonymous with younger, changing cultures due to its usage of terrors to tradition to resist it. As these changes occur, examinations of past expressions of sexuality in Gothic literature can render lavish details of how sexuality and queerness were viewed at the time, as well as how the genre works as a critique of a culture's warped definition of "normal."

Works Cited

Costello-Sullivan, Katherine J., "Introduction." *Carmilla: A Critical Edition* (1872). Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2019.

Le Fanu, J. Sheridan. *Carmilla: A Critical Edition* (1872). Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2019.

Lewis, Matthew Gregory. *The Monk* (1796). Oxford: Oxford World's Classics, 1998.

Oyeyemi, Helen. *White is For Witching* (2009). New York: Riverhead Books, 2010.